

USER_GUIDE

Action Directives – User Guide

Revision: 1 **Last modified:** 2026-07-14T21:50:00Z **Authority:** constitution §11.4.140 (action-prefix system) + §11.4.202 (reporting directives) **Maintainer:** constitution submodule **Scope:** for anyone *using* the directives. If you are wiring them into a project, read [ADMIN_MANUAL.md](#) instead.

Companion documents: [REFERENCE.md](#) · [QUICKSTART_REPORT.md](#) · [QUICKSTART_INSTALL.md](#)

¹

. The idea in one sentence

Start a prompt with a registered UPPERCASE token and that token is replaced by a full, pre-agreed instruction — so you type five characters instead of a paragraph, and the agent behaves the same way every time.

BUG: subtitles render one frame late on the secondary display

...is executed as *“REPORT DIRECTIVE — BUG (§11.4.202). The remainder of this prompt is a REPORT of a product DEFECT... create it through the project’s reporting engine... never merely acknowledged, never silently dropped...”* followed by your actual text.

. The five directives

Directive	Reach for it when	What the agent then does
BUG	Something is broken — a regression, a defect, user-visible wrong behaviour.	Creates a fully-populated Type=Bug workable item (Status Queued , stable ticket id, structured description), regenerates every derived document from the DB, pushes to every configured external tracker, reports the ticket id back — then, if actionable now, investigates it under systematic-debugging (root cause before any fix).
TASK	Internal workstream — a refactor, a doc, infra, a gate, an audit, a chore.	Same pipeline, Type=Task (fixed).
ISSUE	Anything trackable and you have not decided what it is.	Classifies it into the closed set {Bug Feature Task} from the report's own content. If the content does not determine the type it asks you before creating anything. Then the same create + sync + push pipeline.

Directive	Reach for it when	What the agent then does
BACKGROUND	Work that should proceed in parallel with the main stream and must never be lost.	Records the request in the durable background queue immediately (id + timestamp + status + blocker), then runs it subagent-driven in parallel. If it cannot run now it stays QUEUED with its blocker recorded and is re-attempted at the next opportunity — including in a fresh session. It never interrupts the main stream, and it is never silently dropped.
REMINDER	You are re-surfacing earlier work whose status you are unsure of .	Does not assume it is done or not done. First verifies the actual status from captured evidence (git state, the task list, the background queue, test artifacts, the workable-items DB). Then acts on the delta: report the proof if genuinely complete, resume from the exact point if partial, start it now if not started, or surface the block. It always produces a status verdict.

ISSUE is a channel, not a type. There is no “Issue” type — every item is a **Bug** , a **Feature** , or a **Task** .

. How to invoke – six equivalent forms

All six do exactly the same thing. Use whichever you like.

BUG: subtitles are one frame late	← 6. single-colon (what most people type)
BUG :: subtitles are one frame late	← 1. bare ::
DEFAULT::BUG :: subtitles are one frame late	← 2. namespaced ::
BUG ---> subtitles are one frame late	← 5. arrow
/DEFAULT::BUG subtitles are one frame late	← 4. namespaced slash
/bug subtitles are one frame late	← 3. bare slash – SEE §5, /
bug COLLIDES	

The rules, in short:

- **Only the first non-blank line counts.** A token in the middle of a paragraph never triggers.
- **UPPERCASE only.** `bug: ...` is ordinary text.
- **Spacing is exact.** `::` and `--->` need one space on each side; `NAME:` needs the colon tight against the name and one space after it. This is what keeps `std::vector`, YAML `key: value`, and URLs from ever triggering.
- **You can stack them.** `BACKGROUND :: BUG: the HDMI sink drops to stereo` applies the outer directive, then the inner one, then the task.

Worked examples

TASK: bump the pandoc pin to 3.2 and regenerate the exports

ISSUE: playback stutters on 4K HDR after ~40 minutes – happens on both boxes

BACKGROUND ---> audit every gate for a paired mutation and file what is missing

REMINDER: the OTA signing-key rotation we scheduled last week

. Escaping – talking about a directive without firing it

Put a single backslash in front. The backslash is stripped and nothing expands:

```
\BUG: this is an example of the syntax, do not open a ticket  
\BACKGROUND likewise
```

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. The collision: `/bug` vs `/helix:bug` vs `/default-bug`

Claude Code ships its **own built-in** `/bug` (report a bug to Anthropic). The registry declares that collision as `data ( slash_conflicts: [bug] )`, and the system respects it — **the plugin never silently shadows a host command**.

You type	What runs
<code>/bug audio is silent</code>	Claude Code's built-in. Not the directive.
<code>/helix:bug audio is silent</code>	The directive. Plugin namespacing is always unambiguous.
<code>/default-bug audio is silent</code>	The directive. The collision-free alias — works on every agent.
<code>BUG: audio is silent</code>	The directive. No host command can touch this form.
<code>BUG :: audio is silent / BUG ---> audio is silent</code>	The directive.

So: for `BUG`, use `BUG:` (simplest) or `/helix:bug` / `/default-bug`.

The other four directives have **no** declared collision, so their bare slash forms work directly: `/task ...` , `/issue ...` , `/background ...` , `/reminder ...` — and `/helix:task` / `/default-task` remain available if your host ever adds a colliding command.

. What happens if you type a token that is not registered

The system **never invents an expansion** and **never silently drops your prompt**.

You type	What happens
<code>BUGG :: audio is silent</code> (typo, <code>::</code> form)	You are asked which registered directive you meant — with the closest name suggested.
<code>/deploy the new image</code> (unregistered slash)	Same: asked, never guessed.
<code>NOTE: remember to re-flash D4</code> (unregistered single-colon)	Nothing happens — it is treated as an ordinary sentence. This is deliberate: <code>NOTE: /</code> <code>TODO: /</code> <code>WARNING: /</code> <code>FIXME: </code> are normal English, and questioning every one of them would be intolerable.

. Sub-system shortcuts

An UPPERCASE token that is not a directive but *is* an incorporated sub-system or submodule expands to that sub-system's working context (repository, org, where it is checked out, plus the rules for working on it — treat it as an equal part of the codebase, keep it decoupled, fetch first, never force-push):

```
HXQA :: add a Challenge bank entry for the subtitle oracle
HELIXOTA ---> investigate the delta-update failure on the 1.2.1 image
```

Tokens come from the curated catalogue (`HXOTA` , `HXQA` , `HXCODE` , `HXAGENT` , `HXLLM` , `HXMEM` , `HXSPEC` , `HXTRACK` , `LLMSVERIFIER` , `CTOOLKIT` , ...) **and** from your own project's submodules, discovered automatically from `.gitmodules` — a newly-added submodule works with no configuration.

If a token is ambiguous (two sub-systems), it is **dropped** and you are asked. A registered directive always wins over a sub-system of the same name.

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. How to see what is registered

```
# every registered action, one per line
bash -c '. constitution/scripts/action_prefix_lib.sh && apx_list_actions'

# what one directive actually expands to
bash -c '. constitution/scripts/action_prefix_lib.sh && apx_lookup_expansion BUG'

# dry-run the whole expander on a prompt (JSON: verdict / action / expansion / emitted)
bash -c '. constitution/scripts/action_prefix_lib.sh && apx_expand_prompt "BUG: audio is silent"
```

Or just read the source of truth — `constitution/actions/registry.yaml` — and the generated command inventory, `constitution/plugins/helix/README.md` .

In Claude Code, `/helix:` then Tab lists every command the plugin exposes.

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. If a directive does not seem to fire

1. Is it on the **first non-blank line**? A directive in the middle of a prompt never fires.
2. Is it **UPPERCASE**?

3. Is the **spacing exact**? `::` (spaces both sides), `NAME:` (no space before the colon, one after), `--->` (spaces both sides).
4. Did you use a **bare** `/name` **that collides** with a host command (`/bug`)? Use `/helix:bug` or `/default-bug` (§5).
5. Still nothing? The wiring may not be installed in this project — hand [ADMIN_MANUAL.md](#) to whoever set it up, or run the one-line installer in [QUICKSTART_INSTALL.md](#).